

**University of Iowa
Tippie College of Business
Department of Finance
Spring 2026
FIN 3400 – Principles of Risk Management and Insurance**

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Office Hours: Tuesdays 10:30 a.m. – 11:30 a.m. or by appointment
Appointments: <https://calendly.com/zijia>
Class Hours: Monday/Wednesday 9:30 a.m. – 10:45 a.m.
Class Location: S307 PBB

The course syllabus is a general plan for the course; deviations announced to the class by the instructor may be necessary.

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1 Course Site

To access the course site, log into [Iowa Courses Online](#) using your Hawk ID and password. I will use ICON and email for all out-of-class communications. I will post exam dates as well as other information in ICON or send it to you via email. Please be sure that you are enrolled in this ICON course. Review all of the information on ICON.

2 Textbook and Readings

- No textbook required. The course will be based on lecture notes and assigned readings.

Research has shown that students learn better when they take their own notes. As such, I will not be posting my notes. Any student who misses class should reach out to classmates or watch the recordings.

3 Prerequisites

None.

4 Course Overview

This fundamental course aims to provide an introductory, consumer-oriented overview of risk and insurance. Students will be introduced to the basics of the insurance mechanism as well as learn to effectively implement the risk management process. Because risk management and insurance allow the individual and the firm to maintain stability (even when things go wrong), students of all backgrounds will find this class useful.

This course is organized into **three modules**. The **first module** is designed to familiarize you with the basic aspects of risk and risk management as they apply to all firms and individuals. The **second module** presents an overview of how individuals, firms, and society finance losses from random events. The **third module** discusses individual economic security issues, including employee benefits, health care, and retirement plans. Finally, the role of social insurance is discussed, highlighting the public sector's role in risk management in the United States.

This course aims to equip you with an understanding of the principles of risk, which will aid in your understanding of the evolving nature of risk management and insurance and how these concepts will continue to impact firms and the individuals.

5 Learning Objectives

After taking this class, students should be able to:

- Define and classify common types of risks faced by individuals and businesses.
- State and explain the risk management process.
- Define typical risk management techniques and provide appropriate examples of how they are used by individuals and businesses.

- Recognize and apply (legal) insurance principles; defend and critique their suitability in different factual settings.
- Define and explain common insurance policy provisions and demonstrate their implementation in practice.
- Classify different organizational forms of insurers and describe and compare their business operations.
- Explain and identify property and liability loss exposures.
- Describe and explain different types of life and health insurance policies.
- Explain how different life and health insurance policies are used effectively at various stages of one's life.

6 Course Grading and Assessment

Your final grade consists of scores on three midterm exams each worth 150 points.

6.1 Final Grade Determination

At the end of the semester, I will add up all of the points you have accumulated during the course, divide it by the total potential points, and then assign you a grade according to the scale below. As outlined below, you can potentially get extra points through extra credit and *lose* points for missing class.

Point Range	Grade
100.00+	A+
93.00 - 99.99%	A
90.00 - 92.99%	A-
87.00 - 89.99%	B+
83.00 - 86.99%	B
80.00 - 82.99%	B-
77.00 - 79.99%	C+
73.00 - 76.99%	C
70.00 - 72.99%	C-
67.00 - 69.99%	D+
63.00 - 66.99%	D
60.00 - 62.99%	D-
<60.00%	F

Is there a curve? Exam grades are assigned based on your rank order on the exam and the recommended grade distribution for a required course in the undergraduate program: 40% As, 40% Bs, 15% Cs, and 5% Ds. I won't curve (or "round up") final grades for any reason, as this would mess up the curve in the course.

Is there extra credit? There will be the possibility of extra credit. Generally, I will provide extra credit opportunities in class. However, if you are not in class when I give an extra credit assignment you cannot make up that assignment. You can also get extra credit for participating in

selected events organized by the Vaughan Institute and/or our student organization Gamma Iota Sigma (GIS). It is a strategic priority of the Vaughan Institute to help each student start building a professional network prior to graduation, while deepening their understanding of current industry developments and potential career paths.

Receiving Your Final Grade: I do not send or discuss final grades via email or discuss grades on the telephone. The University posts all final grades.

Questions about Your Final Grade: If you have a question about your final grade after the grades are posted, email me and we can set up an appointment to discuss your grade in the next semester. If you are a graduating senior, you may have your advisor contact me to affirm that you are a graduating senior. After I have confirmed this status, we can discuss your grade either in person or via Zoom.

7 Attendance

I will take attendance. You are allowed 3 missed classes with no punishment and, after that, you will lose 5 points for every class that you miss. If you are late, that counts as half an absence. If you have to miss a class and don't want to be punished, you can turn in a "make up" assignment (described below) within two weeks and not have the absence count. Other than excused absences (defined below), there will be zero exceptions to this policy and you do not need to email me if you are not going to be in class.

How will I take attendance? At the beginning of class, I will pass around a sign in sheet. Just sign next to your name. I will then collect it. If you come in late, be sure to come to me at the end of class and I will let you sign in for a "half" absence. Note: Signing in for someone else falls under Academic Dishonesty and will be treated as such. If you have signed into class and are not here when/if your name is called on for a question because you left early, you will be marked absent.

7.1 Excused Absences

The only things that qualify for excused absences for attendance purposes are:

- Religious holy days
- Military service obligations
- Military service-related medical appointments
- Jury duty
- University-sponsored activities such as athletics.

7.2 Make Up Assignment

If you need to make up attendance or any out-of-class extra credit, you can do so by creating, and recording through zoom, a 20 minute presentation on an interesting RMI topic. You must do a different presentation for each thing that you want to make up. The list of potential topics, along with some background sources, is on ICON. You will also need to find additional sources. An additional requirement is that you must visit the Frank Center and have them look over your presentation. Please take a selfie while there for proof. A rubric for the presentations is on Canvas.

In order to have the make-up presentation “count”, you must score at least a 7 out of 10. This is **not** a collaborative activity and any sharing of materials (including across semesters) will be dealt with as academic dishonesty. Presentations will be run through Turnitin.

Presentation recordings, raw slides, and the Frank Center selfie must be emailed to me within 2 weeks of the missed event. The only exception to this is if you have difficulty scheduling an appointment at the Frank Center. In that case, please screenshot the lack of availability and send me a request for an extension.

8 Exams and Case Studies

8.1 Exams

Format: The exams will be multiple choice. However, these multiple choice questions will contain quantitative elements. Most exam questions will come from the practice exams at the link on ICON. Material for the exams, for the most part, will come from the lecture notes and assigned readings. Midterms will be 75 questions and worth 150 points each. Many questions will have multiple correct answers, and partial credit is awarded for only choosing some of the correct answers (as long as no incorrect answers are selected).

Midterm Exam Dates: The first exam will cover Module 1. The second exam will cover Module 2. The third exam will cover Module 3. Specific dates for the exams can be found below. Note, this schedule is subject to change. If due dates must be changed (for whatever reason), I will always strive to give you at least two weeks notice.

Exam 1	Wednesday, March 4 th
Exam 2	Wednesday, April 8 th
Exam 3	Wednesday, May 6 th
Make Up Exam Day	Whenever the university sets it.

9 Class Recording

Students may be enrolled in a class where some sessions will be recorded or live-streamed. Such recordings/streaming will only be available to students registered for the class. These recordings are the intellectual property of the faculty and they may not be shared or reproduced without the explicit, written consent of the faculty member. Further, students may not share these sessions with those not in the class or upload them to any other online environment. Doing so would be a breach of the Code of Student Conduct, and, in some cases, a violation of state and federal law, including the Federal Education Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA).

The unauthorized video or audio recording of academic activities (e.g., lectures, course discussions, office hours, etc.) by a student is prohibited. Students with a reasonable accommodation for recording approved by Student Disability Services should notify each instructor and provide the Letter of Accommodation prior to using the accommodation. A student may record classroom activities with prior written permission from the instructor and notice to other students in the class that audio or video recording may occur. Any and all classroom recording must be for personal academic use only. The distribution, sharing, sale, or posting of recordings on the internet (including social media), in whole or in part, is prohibited and doing so may be a violation of the Code of Student Life and/or state or federal privacy, copyright, or other laws.

10 Administrative Issues

Office Hours and Preferred Method of Contact: I will always be available during office hours. You never need an appointment for office hours – just come to the office! If you cannot come to office hours, I am also willing to schedule an appointment to meet with you at a mutually agreeable time. See below for how to arrange that.

Occasionally, I have meetings scheduled, which may prevent me from holding all of my office hours. I will announce these through ICON in advance. The best way to reach me outside of class is via email. My goal is to be as accessible as possible to you throughout the semester. If you are wandering the halls outside of office hours and my door is open, feel free to come in!

This course emphasizes using the Internet and ICON for all class communications. It is best to communicate with me via email rather than leaving me a phone message. I generally try to respond to all emails within 48 hours. Each student is required to have access to ICON and to use an Iowa email address. Please include the class and the time in the subject line when emailing me.

11 CIC Personal Lines Designation Waiver

This course qualifies for the University Associates Program administered by the Risk & Insurance Education Alliance. To receive your waiver towards the Certified Insurance Counselor (CIC) designation, you must earn a grade of C or better in this course.

See ICON for more information.

12 Collegiate Policies and Guidelines

The administrative home of this course is the Tippie College of Business, which governs academic matters relating to the course such as the add/drop deadlines, the second-grade-only option, issues concerning academic misconduct, and how credits are applied for various graduation requirements. Different colleges might have different policies.

The Tippie College of Business is committed to providing students with a diverse, inclusive, and equitable environment in which to pursue their educations. In addition, Students at Tippie adhere to an honor code that emphasizes the importance of honesty and integrity. Student concerns about this class or your performance in it can be discussed with the instructor or the Associate Dean for Undergraduate Programs. More details about these and other policies are available on the [Tippie website](#).

The University of Iowa is committed to the protection of freedom of speech and the principles of academic and artistic freedom, to accommodating students with disabilities, and to accommodating absences due to religious holidays. In addition, students are expected to comply with the University's Code of Student Life. The University is also committed to non-discrimination and prohibits all forms of sexual harassment, sexual misconduct, and related retaliation. The University also provides resources for student mental health as well as for the basic needs and support of students. More information about these and other policies can be found on the Provost's Office's website.

12.1 Tippie Honor Code:

The Tippie College of Business has an Honor Code, and you must abide by it in completion of all assignments. Integrity is a reflection of your character and is critical for creating meaningful and lasting relationships. One part of integrity is abstaining from acts like cheating, so cheating on any assignment in this class will result in an appropriate consequence, usually a zero for the grade in question and, if that penalty does not reduce the grade, a penalty of a full letter grade reduction. In addition, all incidents of cheating will be reported to the appropriate academic offices, and the student may be placed on disciplinary probation, be suspended, or even permanently expelled, depending on the severity of the offense.

If a student has been found in violation of this policy, they will first be notified directly, then the professor will report to the appropriate program office. Faculty and students can report Academic Misconduct via [this college website](#).

12.2 Privacy:

As part of this course, your name will be revealed to other students in the class. If you have concerns, please contact the instructor immediately.

12.3 Complaint Procedures:

If at any time you have concerns about this class or your performance in it, please contact me directly. If you do not feel that your concern has been resolved satisfactorily, you should contact the Department Executive Officer (DEO) who oversees the department offering this course (erik-lie@uiowa.edu). If that does not resolve the complaint, you may contact the Associate Dean of the Undergraduate Program, Kenneth Brown (kenneth-g-grown@uiowa.edu).

13 University Policies and Guidelines

As a registered student in a course through The University of Iowa, the following University policies apply to you.

13.1 Non-discrimination:

The University of Iowa is committed to making the classroom a respectful and inclusive space for people of all gender, sexual, racial, religious, and other identities. Toward this goal, students are invited in MyUI to optionally share the names and pronouns they would like their instructors and advisors to use to address them. The University of Iowa prohibits discrimination and harassment against individuals on the basis of race, class, gender, sexual orientation, national origin, and other identity categories set forth in the University's Human Rights policy. For more information, contact the [Office of Equal Opportunity and Diversity](#).

13.2 Accommodations for Disabilities:

The University is committed to provide an educational experience that is accessible to all students. If you have a diagnosed disability or any other condition that would impair your ability to complete the course requirements as stated above, please inform me as early in the semester

as possible, but no later than two weeks prior to the scheduled activity. Students needing accommodations must register with [Student Disability Services \(SDS\)](#) to obtain a Student Academic Accommodation Request (SAAR) form. The form will specify what course accommodations are reasonable for that student. The office is located at 3100 Burge Hall, 319-335-1462.

13.3 Mental Health:

Students are encouraged to be mindful of their mental health and seek help if they are feeling overwhelmed or incapable of meeting course expectations. For assistance with the class, students are encouraged to talk to the faculty member. For additional advice or support, students are encouraged to contact [University Counseling Services](#) at University Capital Centre Suite 1950 or 3223 Westlawn South (319-335-7294) for same day appointments (Mon-Fri 8 am - 4:30 pm). After hours, we encourage you to call the Johnson County Crisis Line at 319-351-0140 or 911 if you are in immediate danger.

13.4 Sexual Harassment:

Sexual harassment subverts the mission of the University and threatens the well-being of students, faculty, and staff. The University will not tolerate sexual harassment, nor will it tolerate unwelcomed behavior of a sexual nature toward members of the University community when that behavior creates an intimidating or hostile environment for employment, education, on-campus living, or participation in a University activity. As a member of the university community you have a responsibility to report concerns of sexual harassment immediately at the [Office of the Sexual Misconduct Response Coordinator](#).

13.5 Multicultural Holidays:

Students compelled by their religious convictions to refrain from attending class on specific days must request instructor permission during the first few days of the session. If this request is denied, a student may address concerns according to [University Procedures](#).

13.6 Sustainability:

The University is committed to demonstrating sustainability practices within all facets of the institution. Students are encouraged to utilize recycled materials and use as few natural resources as possible (such as by making use of digital forms of note taking, as appropriate). Recycling of all paper materials is expected. Learn more at the [Office of Sustainability](#).

13.7 Free Speech and Expression:

The University of Iowa supports and upholds the First Amendment protection of freedom of speech and the principles of academic and artistic freedom. We are committed to open inquiry, vigorous debate, and creative expression inside and outside of the classroom. For information on the university's policies on free speech and academic freedom, see <https://freespeech.uiowa.edu>.

13.8 Electronic Devices in the Classroom

Computers, Telephones, Blackberries, iPads, Earphones, and All Other Types of Electronic Devices

I do not permit audio recording, video recording, photo recording, or capture of any kind or media in the classroom or of me at any time or location. If you require a variance to this policy due to medical reasons, please see me. Please see me if you have any questions about this policy.

If I notice you using your phone in class you will be heckled.

Calculators: You will be allowed to use a non-programmable calculator during exams. No graphing calculators or cell phones will be allowed to be used. If you can type English on it without having to turn it upside down you are not allowed to use it (this includes smart watches). I will not bring extra calculators to the exams. If you forget yours, you will have to do the math by hand.

14 Academic Integrity

I expect all students to conduct themselves with the highest degree of ethical behavior. I do not tolerate dishonest or unethical behavior. Students should not tolerate dishonest or unethical behavior. I do not tolerate cheating or plagiarism in any form.

15 Religious Holidays

If you will be observing any religious holidays this semester which will prevent you from fulfilling any course requirement, I will do my best to offer you an opportunity to meet the course requirement if you make arrangements by informing me of the dates of your religious holidays no later than the end of the first week of class.

16 Course Topics and Text Readings

- **Module 1: Intro to Risk**
 - **Topic 1.** Introduction and Overview.
 - **Topic 2.** Quantifying Frequency, Severity, and Total Expected Loss.
 - **Topic 3.** Insurance Pricing and the Characteristics of an Insurable Risk.
- **Module 2: Managing Property and Liability Risks**
 - **Topic 4.** Risk Control
 - **Topic 5.** Traditional and Enterprise Risk Management.
 - **Topic 6.** Compliance, Systemic Risks, and Natural Disasters
- **Module 3: Managing Human Capital Risks**
 - **Topic 7.** Introduction to Employer-Provided Benefits.
 - **Topic 8.** Health Risks.
 - **Topic 9.** Retirement Risks.